

POTENTIAL

1. Passage anchor

> “She also had a sharp eye for **potential**.”

Passage meaning

potential = natural ability or capacity that could develop successfully in the future

潛力；發展潛能

Here, Mrs. Chan was good at recognizing what students **could become capable of**, even before that ability was fully developed.

Practice

1. The coach immediately recognized her **potential**.

教練立刻看出了她的**潛力**。

2. He has enormous **potential**, but he still needs experience.

他有很大的**潛力**，但仍需要累積經驗。

Core meanings of POTENTIAL

2. potential — noun: ability or capacity for future development

= qualities or abilities that may develop and lead to future success

潛力；潛能；發展可能性

This is the passage sense and the most important noun meaning.

Examples

1. She has the **potential** to become an excellent leader.

她有成為優秀領導者的**潛力**。

2. The teacher saw **potential** in a student who lacked confidence.

那位老師在一名缺乏自信的學生身上看到了**潛力**。

Common patterns:

* have potential 有潛力

* show potential 展現潛力

* realize your potential 發揮潛能

- * fulfil your potential 充分發揮潛能
- * reach your full potential 發揮全部潛力
- * untapped potential 尚未開發的潛力

3. potential for something

= possibility or capacity for something to happen or develop

.....的可能性；.....的潛力

Examples

1. The area has great **potential for tourism**.
這個地區具有很大的**觀光發展潛力**。
2. The technology has considerable **potential for growth**.
這項技術具有相當大的**成長潛力**。

This construction often applies to:

- * businesses
- * technologies
- * places
- * systems
- * projects

not only people.

4. potential to do something

= capacity or possibility to develop into, achieve, or cause something

有可能.....；有能力發展到.....

Examples

1. This idea has the **potential to change** the industry.
這個構想**有可能改變**整個產業。
2. The child has the **potential to become** a gifted musician.
這個孩子**有潛力成為**有天分的音樂家。

The exact Chinese can vary:

- * 有潛力.....
- * 有可能.....
- * 具有.....的潛能

depending on whether **ability** or **possibility** is emphasized.

Possibility rather than ability

5. potential — noun: possibility that something could happen

= the possibility of a future event, development, problem, or outcome

****可能性；潛在可能****

Examples

1. We need to consider the **potential** for further delays.
我們需要考慮進一步延誤的****可能性****。
2. The situation has the **potential** for serious conflict.
這種情況存在發生嚴重衝突的****可能性****。

This is conceptually close to “capacity,” but it does not necessarily imply talent or ability.

Adjective meanings

6. potential — adjective: possible in the future

= possible, but not yet actual or certain

****潛在的；可能的****

Examples

1. The company is looking for **potential investors**.
公司正在尋找****潛在投資者****。
2. We discussed several **potential solutions**.
我們討論了幾種****可能的解決方案****。

This is one of the most common uses of the adjective.

7. potential customer / buyer / client

= someone who might become a customer, buyer, or client

潛在顧客 / 買家 / 客戶

Examples

1. The website is designed to attract **potential customers**.
這個網站旨在吸引**潛在顧客**。

2. She met several **potential clients** at the conference.
她在會議上遇到了幾位**潛在客戶**。

Here, **potential** means:

可能成為.....的

not “talented.”

8. potential problem / risk / danger / threat

= something that could become a problem, risk, danger, or threat

潛在的問題 / 風險 / 危險 / 威脅

Examples

1. We identified several **potential problems** before launch.
我們在推出之前發現了幾個**潛在問題**。

2. Security experts warned about a **potential threat**.
安全專家警告了一項**潛在威脅**。

This often appears in formal, academic, technical, and business English.

9. potential benefit / advantage / opportunity

= a benefit, advantage, or opportunity that may be realized

潛在利益 ; 潛在優勢 ; 潛在機會

Examples

1. The project offers several **potential benefits**.
這個計畫帶來幾項**潛在好處**。

2. We should consider both the risks and the **potential advantages**.
我們應同時考慮風險和**潛在優勢**。

10. potential cause / source / explanation

= a possible cause, source, or explanation

可能的原因 / 來源 / 解釋

Examples

1. Researchers examined several **potential causes** of the decline.
研究人員檢視了這種下降現象的幾個**可能原因**。
2. Stress is one **potential explanation** for the symptoms.
壓力是這些症狀的一個**可能解釋**。

Human-development sense

11. someone's full potential

= the highest level of ability or achievement that a person could realistically develop
全部潛能 ; 最大潛力

Examples

1. Good teachers help students reach their **full potential**.
優秀的老師幫助學生**充分發揮潛能**。
2. She never felt that she had achieved her **full potential**.
她一直覺得自己尚未**充分發揮潛力**。

Very high-value expression.

12. realize / fulfil one's potential

= develop and use one's abilities as fully as possible
發揮潛能 ; 實現潛力

Examples

1. Supportive parents can help children **realize their potential**.
有支持性的父母可以幫助孩子**發揮潛能**。

2. He moved abroad to **fulfil his potential** as a musician.
他移居海外，希望能以音樂家的身分**充分發揮自己的潛力**。

Regional preference may vary:

* **realize your potential** is very common

* **fulfil/fulfill your potential** is also common

13. untapped potential

= ability, resources, or opportunity that exists but has not yet been used or developed
尚未開發的潛力；未被發掘的潛能

Examples

1. The region has enormous **untapped potential** for renewable energy.
這個地區在再生能源方面具有巨大的**未開發潛力**。

2. The manager believed the team had a lot of **untapped potential**.
經理認為這支團隊仍有許多**尚未發揮的潛力**。

14. hidden potential

= ability or capacity that is present but not yet obvious
隱藏的潛力；尚未顯現的潛能

Examples

1. The programme helps young people discover their **hidden potential**.
這個計畫幫助年輕人發掘自己的**隱藏潛能**。

2. She saw **hidden potential** in the quiet student.
她在那名安靜的學生身上看到了**尚未顯現的潛力**。

Business, places, systems

15. market potential

= possible future demand, sales, or commercial opportunity in a market

****市場潛力；市場潛能****

Examples

1. Analysts are assessing the product's ****market potential****.
分析師正在評估這項產品的****市場潛力****。
2. The region has strong ****market potential**** for electric vehicles.
該地區在電動車方面具有很強的****市場潛力****。

16. growth potential

= capacity for future growth

****成長潛力；發展潛力****

Examples

1. Investors prefer companies with strong ****growth potential****.
投資者偏好具有強大****成長潛力****的公司。
2. The industry still has considerable ****growth potential****.
這個產業仍具有相當大的****發展潛力****。

17. earning potential

= amount of money someone could potentially earn

****賺錢潛力；收入潛力****

Examples

1. Additional qualifications may increase your ****earning potential****.
額外的資格可能提高你的****收入潛力****。
2. He chose the career partly because of its high ****earning potential****.
他選擇這個職業，部分原因是它具有較高的****收入潛力****。

18. development potential

= capacity of a place, project, person, or system for future development

****發展潛力****

Examples

1. The land has significant ****development potential****.

這塊土地具有很大的****開發潛力****。

2. The report evaluates the region's economic ****development potential****.

這份報告評估該地區的經濟****發展潛力****。

Scientific and technical meanings

19. potential — physics: capacity associated with position or state

In physics, ****potential**** refers to a quantity related to the ability of a system to produce an effect because of position, configuration, or field conditions.

Traditional Chinese depends on the compound.

Examples include:

* electric potential ****電勢****

* gravitational potential ****重力勢****

* potential energy ****位能****

This is a genuinely distinct technical branch.

20. potential energy

= stored energy resulting from position, configuration, or condition

****位能 ; 勢能****

Examples

1. Water stored behind a dam has gravitational ****potential energy****.

水壩後儲存的水具有重力****位能****。

2. A stretched spring contains elastic ****potential energy****.

拉伸的彈簧具有彈性****位能****。

Important contrast:

* **potential energy** = stored/position-related energy

* **kinetic energy** = energy of motion

21. electric potential

= electric potential energy per unit charge at a point

電勢

Examples

1. The electric **potential** differs between the two points.

這兩點之間的**電勢**不同。

2. Voltage represents a difference in electric **potential**.

電壓表示電**勢**之間的差異。

This is specialist scientific usage and should not be confused with everyday “possibility.”

22. potential difference

= difference in electric potential between two points

電勢差；電位差

Examples

1. A **potential difference** exists across the battery terminals.

電池兩端存在**電勢差**。

2. The voltmeter measures **potential difference**.

電壓表測量**電勢差**。

Technical but established.

Grammar and semantic distinction

23. potential as a noun

Human ability

She has enormous ****potential****.
她有很大的****潛力****。

Future possibility

There is ****potential**** for conflict.
存在發生衝突的****可能性****。

Technical quantity

Measure the electric ****potential****.
測量電****勢****。

So the noun is not limited to “talent.”

24. potential as an adjective

****potential + noun****

= possible or capable of becoming actual in the future

Examples:

- * potential customer 潛在顧客
- * potential candidate 潛在人選
- * potential risk 潛在風險
- * potential solution 可能的解決方案
- * potential benefit 潛在利益

Practice

1. She is a ****potential candidate**** for the position.
她是這個職位的****潛在人選****。
2. We need to identify ****potential risks**** early.
我們需要及早找出****潛在風險****。

Important distinctions

25. potential vs possibility

****possibility****

= chance that something may happen

****可能性****

****potential****

= capacity for future development OR possibility inherent in something

****潛力；潛能；潛在可能性****

Compare:

There is a ****possibility**** that she will win.

= 她有可能會贏。

She has the ****potential**** to win major competitions.

= 她具備未來贏得大型比賽的****潛力****。

The second says more about ****capacity****, not merely chance.

26. potential vs ability

****ability****

= skill or capacity someone already has

****能力****

****potential****

= ability that may develop further or become fully realized

****潛力****

Compare

He has the ****ability**** to solve difficult problems.

他有解決難題的****能力****。

He has the ****potential**** to become an excellent researcher.

他有成為優秀研究員的****潛力****。

27. potential vs talent

****talent****

= natural ability, usually already observable

****天賦；才華****

****potential****

= possibility of future development or achievement

****潛力****

A person may show ****talent**** now and still have much greater ****potential**** for the future.

28. potential vs capacity

****capacity****

= ability, power, or maximum amount that something can contain/do

****能力；容量；承載力****

****potential****

= unrealized capacity or future possibility

****潛力；潛在可能****

Compare:

The machine has the ****capacity**** to process 1,000 items per hour.

這台機器每小時有處理一千件物品的****能力****。

The technology has the ****potential**** to transform the industry.

這項技術具有改變整個產業的****潛力****。

29. potential vs prospective

Both can describe something connected with the future, but they differ.

****potential****

= possible; may become actual

****潛在的****

****prospective****

= expected or likely to become something, especially a person in a future role

****未來可能成為.....的；準.....****

Examples:

* potential customer 潛在顧客

* prospective student 準學生 / 有意入學的學生

* prospective employer 未來可能的雇主

They overlap in some contexts but are not fully interchangeable.

Useful word-family forms

30. potentially

= possibly; in a way that could develop into or cause something

****可能地；潛在地；有可能****

Examples

1. The mistake could be ****potentially dangerous****.

這個錯誤****可能具有危險性****。

2. The discovery is ****potentially very important****.

這項發現****可能非常重要****。

31. potentially + adjective

Very common combinations include:

* potentially harmful 可能有害的

* potentially dangerous 可能危險的

* potentially useful 可能有用的

* potentially serious 可能嚴重的

* potentially valuable 可能很有價值的

Examples

1. This is a ****potentially serious problem****.

這是一個****可能很嚴重的問題****。

2. The data could be ****potentially useful**** for future research.

這些資料對未來研究而言****可能很有用****。

High-value expressions

32. see potential in someone / something

= recognize capacity for future development or success

****看出.....的潛力****

Examples

1. The teacher ****saw potential in him**** immediately.
老師立刻****看出了他的潛力****。
2. Investors ****see potential in**** the new technology.
投資者****看好這項新技術的發展潛力****。

This is especially close to the passage.

33. show potential

= demonstrate signs of future ability or success
****展現潛力****

Examples

1. She ****showed great potential**** as a writer.
她**展現出成為作家的巨大潛力**。
2. The young player is already ****showing potential****.
這名年輕球員已經開始****展現潛力****。

34. have great / enormous / considerable potential

= possess strong capacity for development
****有很大的 / 巨大的 / 相當大的潛力****

Examples

1. The project has ****enormous potential****.
這個計畫具有****巨大潛力****。
2. She is young but has ****considerable potential****.
她年紀雖輕，卻有****相當大的潛力****。

35. unlock someone's / something's potential

= make it possible for hidden or unrealized capacity to develop

****釋放潛能；開發潛力****

Examples

1. Good education can ****unlock a child's potential****.
良好的教育可以****激發孩子的潛能****。
2. The investment could ****unlock the region's economic potential****.
這項投資可能****釋放該地區的經濟發展潛力****。

36. maximize potential

= develop or use capacity as fully as possible

****最大化潛力；充分發揮潛能****

Examples

1. The training programme is designed to ****maximize each athlete's potential****.
這項訓練計畫旨在****充分發揮每位運動員的潛能****。
2. Better planning could ****maximize the site's potential****.
更好的規劃可以****充分發揮這塊土地的潛力****。

Meaning map

The central idea behind ****potential**** is:

****something is not fully actual yet, but the capacity or possibility exists****

From that core idea, several branches develop:

****future human ability****

→ a student's potential

→ ****潛力 / 潛能****

****future development of a thing****

→ market potential

→ ****發展潛力****

****future occurrence****

→ potential for conflict

→ ****可能性****

****possible future person/thing****

→ potential customer / potential problem

→ ****潛在的****

****stored scientific capacity****

→ potential energy / electric potential

→ ****位能 / 電勢****

So the common thread is:

****not fully realized now, but capable of becoming actual or producing an effect****

Passage recap

> “She also had a sharp eye for ****potential****.”

Here:

****potential**** = qualities or abilities in a person that could develop into future success

Best Traditional Chinese renderings:

* ****潛力****

* ****潛能****

* ****發展潛力****

So:

****a sharp eye for potential****

= ****很善於看出別人的潛力****

= ****對人的發展潛能有敏銳的眼光****

MCQ-ready meaning

****potential**** in the passage

= ****ability or capacity that may develop successfully in the future****

****尚未完全發揮、但未來可以發展的能力；潛力****

It does ****not**** mean merely:

* current ability ****現有能力的****

* certainty **必然性**

* ordinary possibility with no underlying capacity **一般可能性**